

Clash of Interests

MPs with a business agenda are members of various panels

T. SUBBARAMI REDDY

Rajya Sabha, Andhra Pradesh (INC)

BUSINESS INTERESTS

With assets worth Rs 239.6 crore, he built the Gayatri Group, now headed by his wife, which has interests in infrastructure, steel, power and mines



MEMBER OF...

the Committee on Public Undertakings, though his Group has public sector units as its clients

PRABHAKAR B. KORE

Rajya Sabha, Karnataka (BJP)

BUSINESS INTERESTS

Chairman of the Karnataka Lingayat Education Society, which runs no less than 152 institutions right from kindergarten to the postgraduate level



MEMBER OF...

the committee on health and family welfare; his society runs a number of medical institutions

DATTA RAGHOBAJI MEGHE

Lok Sabha, Wardha, Maharashtra (INC)

BUSINESS INTERESTS

The four-time MP is the president of the Maharashtra-based Radhikabai Meghe Memorial Medical Trust. His declared assets are worth Rs 35 crore.



MEMBER OF...

the committee on health and family welfare, though he manages a trust that runs medical colleges

BADRUDDIN AJMAL

Lok Sabha, Dhubri, Assam (AUDF)

BUSINESS INTERESTS

The perfume baron is the chairman of Ajmal group of companies with interests in textiles, leather, properties, rubber plantation and cosmetic industries



MEMBER OF...

the Standing Committee on Industry, he is the lone member of the AUDF in Parliament

sion on the Reliance gas-sharing issue. But Nathwani chose to declare before his speech that he was associated with RIL. This prompted Karat to write to Chairman Hamid Ansari asking him to disallow members who have such links from participating in discussions on related issues. "He was only adhering to the advice of the Ethics Committee by declaring his association. If a member has an interest, he has to declare it. You cannot prevent a member from speaking in the House," Khan said.

To find a solution, India may look

to the United Kingdom for answers. In the House of Lords, the members have to declare their interests suo moto when speaking in the House. Even paid visits in the UK and overseas are to be registered. Consider an earlier entry by British Prime Minister Gordon Brown in the registry of members' interests when he was just an MP: "On accompanying visits to Washington, New York and Sydney in September, my wife and baby were upgraded by Virgin Atlantic Airways."

The arrival of industry captains

has made Parliament take a lenient view on the issue. To retain respect for the House, the presiding officers of both the Houses should be offered a set of toothy rules. "The current set of rules is not strong enough. There is hardly any mention of any punitive action against the MPs who refuse to divulge their interests," says Anil Bairwal of the Association for Democratic Reforms. A mechanism should be evolved to cross-check details of members in the interest registry in the Rajya Sabha and make MPs declare the source of wealth or their changing business interests. The Rajya Sabha members' registry needs to go online as the present system of stonewalling information negates the concept of scrutiny.

The members, before they speak in the House, should feel a moral compulsion and suo moto declare their interests. The Lok Sabha, on its part, should rush to prepare its own members' interest register. A monitoring mechanism should also be put in place, like in Canada, to look into the violations on a daily basis. Public confidence in the way parliamentarians discharge their duties depends, to a large extent, on the presumption that they will not deal with matters in Parliament in which they have a conflicting professional or personal interest.

The answer can be found even in a historical quirk. As early as 1951, an investigation was held into the conduct of member of Parliament H.G. Mudgal, who acted on behalf of the Bombay Bullion Association, for extending favours to them in Parliament. Prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru summarised the issue succinctly, "I do submit that it has become a duty for us to be clear, precise and definite. The facts are clear and precise, and the decision should be clear, precise and unambiguous. And I submit, the House should resolve that member should be expelled from the House." This piece of Nehruvian morality seems to have no takers in Parliament today. ■